which passed from the left of my gun position about 150 to 200 yards [140 to 180 metres] away. Some of the people were yelling at us to hold on and keep the enemy at bay. Surprisingly, some of the officers who passed that way did not bother to stop and ask a young officer if he needed any help. All they wanted from us was to keep on firing at the Chinese so that they do not follow them uninterrupted. I felt ashamed of those who were running away. I felt proud of my troop; everybody wanted to fight it out at the gun position.'

But when the direct firing of guns became impossible, Behl gave the order to dismantle the guns. Although a large number of people from all ranks fled past their position, the gunners of 17 Para Field held on. 'They saw a large number of all ranks running past our gun position but not even one person deserted,' said Behl with justifiable pride, after he retired as a brigadier. At 3 p.m. when they had expended most of their ammunition, they surrendered. They were made to spend the night at Tsangdhar. The next morning, Behl requested permission from the Chinese officer to bury the helicopter pilot and the dead major. Giving them as dignified a burial as he could as a POW, Behl managed to identify the two officers as Squadron Leader Vinod Sehgal and Major Ram Singh of the Corps of Signals.

Within a few hours on 20 October, 7 Brigade disintegrated as a formation. Failure to react to Chinese moves allowed the enemy to bring a large number of troops to bear down on individual platoons and companies. Where the officers and JCOs stood their ground, the men responded superbly. Where the officers (whatever their rationale) upped and withdrew, the men had no choice but to follow, and soon it was each man for himself, with many meeting their end trying to escape.

All this while, the small detachment of Sikh gunners from 17 Para Field was standing firm, with no intention of joining the exodus of fleeing officers and men. Unfortunately, most of the subsequent records relied heavily on the accounts of those who ran, their coloured accounts also determining the gallantry awards that were subsequently handed out. By the time those who fought and survived returned from Chinese captivity, no one was interested in their version of what happened. Lieutenant Colonel Rikh, for example, after his repatriation from China, had recommended Major B. K. Pant for a Param Vir Chakra. The citation was ignored as 'the file was closed'. The same was the case with Lieutenant Bikram Singh of 6 Kumaon in the Walong Sector where his CO, Lieutenant Colonel C. N. Madiah,